

Spinach and sun-dried tomato manicotti

Traditionally stuffed with three cheeses—Parmesan, ricotta, and mozzarella—plus herbs and spices, cheese manicotti is **creamy**, a little tangy, and always comforting. In this recipe, tofu replaces the cheese; nutritional yeast imparts a slight cheesy tang. For convenience, if you don't want to bake and eat the manicotti at once, cover and refrigerate or freeze to cook another time.

1 ounce sun-dried tomatoes [30g]

1 pound soft tofu, pressed to remove excess water [500g]

2 tablespoons lemon juice

1 tablespoon nutritional yeast

½ teaspoon salt

Freshly ground pepper

2 tablespoons olive oil

1 small onion, finely chopped

3 garlic cloves, minced

4 ounces fresh spinach, washed, tough stems removed, leaves coarsely chopped [125g]

2 cups homemade or jarred tomato pasta sauce [500ml]

10 manicotti shells, boiled until softened but not limp

1. **Soak** the sun-dried tomatoes in 2 cups [500ml] hot water until soft, about 30 minutes. Coarsely chop the tomatoes; reserve the soaking liquid.
2. In a food processor, **blend** the sun-dried tomatoes with 2 tablespoons of the soaking liquid until coarsely chopped. Crumble the tofu into the processor. Add the lemon juice, nutritional yeast, salt, and a generous grinding of pepper. Blend, scraping down the sides 2 or 3 times, until smooth. Set the filling aside.
3. In a large skillet, **heat** the olive oil over medium-low heat. Add the onion and cook until very soft and slightly browned, 7 to 9 minutes. Add the garlic and spinach to the skillet and cook for about a minute, until the spinach just wilts.

4. Add the spinach and onion mixture to the food processor with the tofu and **blend** until very smooth and creamy. Remove to a covered bowl for at least 1 hour or proceed to stuffing the manicotti shells. (This procedure can be done a day ahead or the morning you plan to serve.)
5. **Preheat** the oven to 325°F [160°C]. Lightly layer a baking dish with some of the tomato sauce. Fill a pastry bag with tofu filling. Gently fill each shell (or at least 8) until nearly full. If you don't have a pastry bag, use a small spoon. Arrange the stuffed shells side by side in the baking dish. Spoon the remainder of the tomato sauce on top.
6. Cover the dish with foil and **bake** for 30 to 40 minutes. To test for doneness, pierce the center of a shell for a couple of seconds with a small sharp knife. The knife tip should be hot.

SERVES 4

chef's tip

For best results, I strongly recommend purchasing a pastry bag, even if it is disposable, to stuff the manicotti shells.